

Module 1: Foundations of Global Migration

Graduate Research Project

Competing Frameworks: A Critical Synthesis of Migration Theory

Overview

A structured literature review that critically evaluates the major theoretical frameworks of migration and tests them against one contemporary migration flow of your choice.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Critically evaluate migration frameworks (Grad 1)
- Synthesize competing definitions across disciplines (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- Which framework best explains a chosen contemporary flow (e.g., Venezuela–Colombia, West Africa–Canary Islands), and where does it fail?
- How do definitional choices (migrant vs. refugee vs. IDP) change what each theory can see?
- What does Carling's aspiration/ability model add that classic push–pull cannot capture?

Methods

Systematic reading of 10–12 peer-reviewed sources (start from the module reading list: Massey et al. 1993; de Haas 2010; Carling 2002, 2024), followed by a single-case application using published data (UN DESA, IOM, UNHCR). No human subjects.

IRB / research ethics

Not required — secondary literature and published data only.

Deliverables

- 4,000–5,000-word critical review with a one-page visual 'theory map'
- 15-minute seminar presentation defending your framework assessment

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Accuracy and coverage of the theoretical landscape 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: accuracy and coverage of the theoretical landscape is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: accuracy and coverage of the theoretical landscape is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: accuracy and coverage of the theoretical landscape is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: accuracy and coverage of the theoretical landscape is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Quality of critical evaluation, not just summary 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of critical evaluation, not just summary goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of critical evaluation, not just summary is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of critical evaluation, not just summary is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of critical evaluation, not just summary is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Rigor of the case application 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: rigor of the case application goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: rigor of the case application is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: rigor of the case application is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: rigor of the case application is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Writing, citation, and presentation 15%	Communication is publication-ready: writing, citation, and presentation is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: writing, citation, and presentation is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: writing, citation, and presentation is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: writing, citation, and presentation is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.